system models—centralized, federated, and decentralized—distribute control and responsibility for managing identity and the attributes that drive policy-based authorization.

No matter how strong our technical decisions are, we must remember that trust—one of the primary reasons we build identity systems—doesn't come from technology alone. While identity systems can inspire technical confidence through strong authentication and verified attributes, true trust requires governance—oversight that ensures the policies, processes, and outcomes reflect organizational values, regulatory requirements, and social expectations. Finally, remember that privacy, confidentiality, and authenticity play in identity and authorization, showing how policy-based authorization (PBAC) can both protect sensitive data and ensure access decisions respect privacy and regulatory constraints.

All of these ideas come together at the moment of authentication—the first time a system asks, “Who are you?” Authentication is where the relationship is renewed, and where many of the tradeoffs between privacy, usability, and security are made. In the next chapter, we’ll explore the role of authentication in preserving relationship integrity, the different methods used to establish confidence, and how the identity lifecycle depends on strong, well-governed authentication to maintain the trustworthiness of every digital relationship over time.

2.9 Summary

- Digital identity powers digital relationships, allowing systems to recognize, remember, and relate to people and organizations, forming the foundation for personalization, security, privacy, and access control.
- Namespaces and discovery are critical to authorization. If a system can’t uniquely name and reliably find identities, policies fail. Structured namespaces help ensure clarity, uniqueness, and correct policy application.
- Identity system models shape control and trust. Centralized, federated, and decentralized systems distribute authority differently, impacting portability, governance, and attribute availability.